

BEING GENUINELY UNSELFISH # 14

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Develop a realistic sense of self without narcissistic grandiosity, exaggeration, or sense of entitlement.
2. Understand the relationship between narcissistic traits and addiction.
3. Develop empathy for other people, particularly victims of the client's narcissism.
4. Identify a role model and examine that person's life for unselfish behavior.
5. Identify and plan ways to become less selfish in daily life.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE NARCISSISTIC TRAITS

- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Forming Stable Relationships
- Getting Out of Myself
- Learning to Ask Instead of Demand
- Seeing That We're All Just Human
- Understanding My Defense Mechanisms
- What Do I Want for My Children?

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The "Becoming Genuinely Unselfish" activity targets self-centeredness, one of the core characteristics of both narcissism and addiction. It does so through examination of the benefits of becoming unselfish in terms of enhanced self-esteem and improved relationships, guiding the client in identifying a role model and examining the ways that person models unselfish actions, and planning specific strategies to implement anonymous (to avoid motives of impressing or manipulating others) acts of generosity in daily life. Follow-up could include videotherapy using films such as *Amelie*, or others recommended in the book *Rent Two Films and Let's Talk in the Morning* by John W. Hesley and Jan G. Hesley, also published by John Wiley & Sons, as well as keeping a journal on the outcomes of actions planned in this exercise.

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What's the point of being unselfish? In a way, it seems like a contradiction to ask, "If I'm unselfish, what's in it for me?" because the question itself seems selfish. However, it can be answered. For many reasons, being truly generous and unselfish helps people break addictive patterns and stay sober. This exercise will help you to decide whether this is worthwhile for you and why, and if you do want to become a less selfish person, to find some ways to work on it.

1. Why do you think it might help you live a happier life to become more unselfish?

Some answers might include: increased self--respect, better relationships with other people, less frustration and envy, and a better connection with your spiritual values. Do any of these make sense to you and sound like what you want?

2. Name a person that you trust, admire, would go to for help with a problem, and want to be like: . Now give some examples of ways this person is unselfish:

Could you do some of the same things? Which ones?

3. The word "genuinely" in the title of this activity means that the unselfishness has to be real, not for show to impress people or manipulate them. The best way to do this is to practice doing at least one generous thing a day and not letting anyone else know about it. What are some generous things you could do each day without anyone else knowing, including the people you do them for?

4. How do you think it would change your thoughts and feelings about yourself to do this?

5. Do you think this would make a difference in your ability to live the life you want to live?

6. Use this space to describe your plan to become more unselfish in your daily life.
